

# Leaf scald

21/12/2025

**Leaf rust, also known as crown rust in oats, is a common disease infecting wheat, barley and oat crops throughout Australia. A specific fungal pathogen causes the disease in each crop, so spread from one crop to the other isn't possible. In susceptible wheat and barley varieties, yield losses of up to 30 and 45 per cent respectively can occur, whilst reductions in forage and grain yields are common in oats.**



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Leaf rust requires green host plants, often referred to as a 'green bridge', to survive from one season to the next. Hosts include volunteer cereals and some weed species. Wet summers favour the growth of a green bridge and therefore the risk of early rust infections is increased, particularly when followed by wet, warm (10 – 22 °C) and humid spring conditions. Initially, leaf rust appears as a 'hot spot' of infection, from which wind-borne spores rapidly spread the disease throughout the crop.

## Control

There are a number of strategies available particularly to prevent leaf rust, which should be the focus rather than relying on curative measures. To prevent or reduce yield losses from leaf rust it is essential to plant resistant varieties. Growers should utilise the most up-to-date leaf rust ratings for the varieties of cereals grown in their regions.

The green bridge should be controlled or removed, either by grazing or spraying volunteer cereals and weeds out at least four weeks prior to sowing. This will help reduce the risk of an early infection.

Crops should be monitored for symptoms and where no seed treatment has been used, a protectant fungicide spray applied at first node is recommended, particularly in high risk crops. Many current fungicides are effective as protectants only. In contrast, Prosaro® and Aviato® XPro® have both protectant and curative properties which both protect the crop from new infections and control recent infections.

Prosaro is registered for the control of leaf rust in barley (*Puccinia hordei*), oats

[View the full list of registered crops and diseases for Prosaro and Aviato XPro](#)

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